

PREHISTORY TO 600CE

DYES AND PIGMENTS

There was much more colour in the ancient world than many faded objects and buildings that remain would suggest. Mixing naturally occurring pigments with water or oil is evident in prehistoric cave paintings, and ancient people found colours to dye cloth, decorate their skin, and create jewellery. The most commonly used dyes and pigments were locally available. Many came from plants; insects were the source of a few rich colours, and rocks, minerals, or earth provided others. The best quality, rarest, and most expensive dyes, such as Tyrian purple from sea snails, were traded across cultures and continents. Colour – sometimes in the form of pattern – differentiated class, customs, and geographic origin. It could also be symbolic.

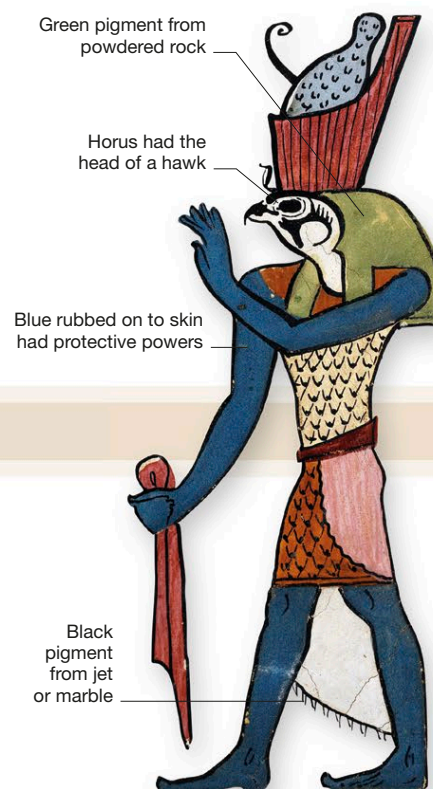


Bright colours Ancient Greek statues and buildings were vividly painted with mineral pigments and indigo when they were first made. This reproduction of an archer from c.490 BCE suggests how these statues appeared.

Sources of dye for black trim of cloak were tree bark, oak galls, green walnuts, and other plants containing tannic acid



Red Swathed in two tones of red, this female figure is depicted on an Etruscan jar from the 6th century BCE. The word “crimson” comes from kermes, an insect that feeds on holm oaks in the Mediterranean, and the source of the dye.



Ancient Egyptian blue This detail from the back of a mummy mask shows Horus, god of the sky and protector of the ruler of Egypt. Blue, the colour of the sky and so of heaven, was used symbolically in honour of the dead.